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Epidemiological Anthropology

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What is Epidemiology

- It is the study of the distribution and determinants of health-related states or events (including diseases) and the application of this study to the control of diseases and other health problems
- Epidemiology is the corner-stone method of public health research and helps in
  - informed policy decisions,
  - evidence-based medicine and
  - better targeting of preventive medicine

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Epidemiological Anthropology

- What can anthropology contribute to the epidemiological study of health and disease?
- The relation between the two sciences – growing since two decades

1. Most of chronic, non-infectious diseases are caused by a number of life-style variables which are social and cultural in nature - an understanding of social and cultural factors is imperative

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Epidemiological Anthropology

2. The spread of human diseases and their control depends to a very great extent on social and cultural factors

3. Disease etiology now requires understanding psychological, biological and socio-cultural characteristics of the hosts rather than exclusive concern with exposure to particular agent

4. Anthropologists on the other hand have shown increasing interest in potential contribution anthropology can make to public health, disease occurrence etc.

- These factors led to the interdisciplinary approach of EA

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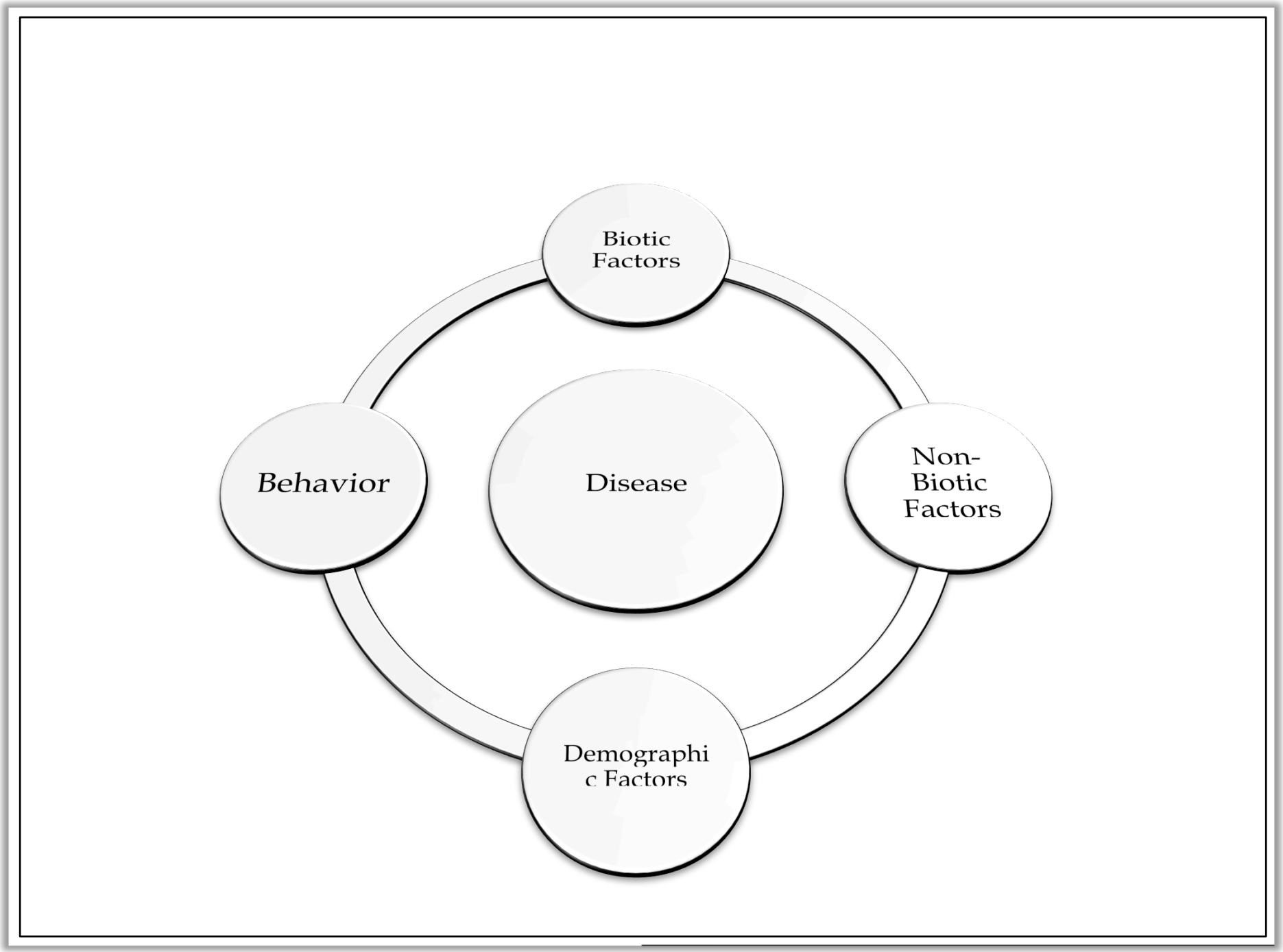
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The Causal Web

- The interdisciplinary approach of EA revealed that nay human disease or disorder is the result of many factors within a "causal web" – a web of determinants
- The "web" includes
  - Exogenous Factors – Biotic and Non-biotic
  - Endogenous Factors – Genetic
  - Demographic Factors
  - Behavior – Social, cultural and psychological
- **It is the goal of EA to identify and measure the relative importance of factors within this causal web of disease**
- A specialization within the parent discipline of Medical Anthropology

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Health & Disease

What is Health?

- Can be defined based on some measured values like temperature, pulse, breathing rates, BP, height, weight etc – which are biological criteria based on statistical concepts
- Can also be defined as an ability to function effectively in complete harmony with one's environment – the ability to meet physical, emotional and mental stresses of life
- Hence, health is more than physical fitness – it involves social, mental and emotional well-being

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Health & Disease

What is Disease?

- In very simple terms, it is any bio-medical deviance
- Though disease and "illness" are used interchangeably, they are not the same!
- **A person may have a disease for many years without even being aware of its presence – i.e., he is diseased but not ill**
- A person with the disease Diabetes is no ill as long as he takes insulin
- Many cancers – go undetected till they cause symptoms – disease vs illness dichotomy

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Health & Disease

- Hence, illness is the **subjective and social experience of disease**
- **It also implies discomfort and inability to function optimally**
- A disease is any deviation from normal form and function
- Hence, a disease is any departure from health – biological or behavioral
- Diseases can be acute or chronic and malignant or benign

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Acute Vs Chronic

Acute or Chronic Diseases

- Acute diseases begin abruptly and are over soon
- Ex. Acute appendicitis – nausea, vomiting, pain in the lower right side of the abdomen – requires immediate surgery
- Chronic refers to a process that begins very gradually and persists over a long period of time
- Ex. Ulcerative Colitis – inflammatory condition limited to colon – peak incidence is in the second decade of life – relapsing attacks of bloody diarrhea for weeks to months alternating with asymptomatic periods for weeks to years

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Benign VS Malignant

- Most often used to explain tumors and also in general sense
- Benign diseases are generally without complications and a good prognosis (the outcome of disease) is usual
- Ex. Wart on the skin – caused by a virus – produces no illnesses and usually disappears given time
- Malignancy implies a process that, if left alone, will result in fatal illness
- Ex. Cancer is a general term for malignant situations

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Classification of Diseases

- Variously classified
  - Topographic – by bodily region – Ex. Gastrointestinal
  - Anatomic – by organ or tissue – Heart disease or liver etc
  - Physiological – by function or effect –Metabolic or respiratory etc
  - Pathological – by nature of disease process – Neoplastic (tumors, cancers) or Inflammatory
  - Etiologic – Causal factors – Bacterial, viral, fungal etc
  - Epidemiological – by distribution, incidence etc.

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